

## OBITUARY I V. P. SINGH 1931-2008

### THE MANDAL MESSIAH WAS THE GREAT SOCIAL SUBVERTER OF INDIAN POLITICS

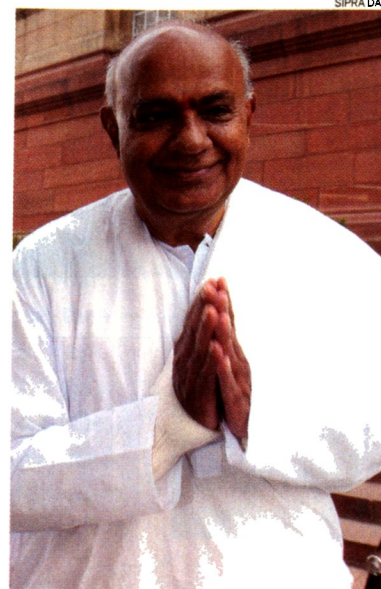


**W**e perhaps need the still lingering glow of a flaming metaphor from the last decade of the last century to make sense of the pyre on the Ganga in Allahabad on November 29 that marked the end of one of the most adventurous journeys in Indian politics. Delhi University student Rajeev Goswami's protest by fire—his thwarted martyrdom—was a rejoinder to Prime Minister Vishwanath Pratap Singh's act of social subversion which would become the most divisive M-word in our political glossary. Singh's pledge to implement the Mandal Commission report (which recommended 27.5 per cent reservation in government jobs for the obc), declared from the Red Fort on Independence Day in 1990, was a revolutionary gesture—and political kitsch as mass seduction. Mandal, with caste as its core and merit its casualty, divided the mind of India and made the Raja from Manda—our first prime minister to lead a minority government—the great disrupter of social hierarchy. His reign of 11 months may not have given him enough time to play out the script of messianism, but the spectre of Mandal would haunt the heartlands of caste. Mandal would reconstruct the politics of India, and many social therapists with a caste agenda would be born out of it. As a politician, he lived by principles, no matter what paranoia and insecurities drove those principles. In his autumnal days of political isolation, he sought solace in playing the double roles of patron saint of secularism and counsellor at large. In the end, the man who shook India with the politics of social justice remained unscarred by realpolitik—and consoled by poetry and painting. —S.P.

## BANGALORE | Pen Drive

**A**fter Jawaharlal Nehru, I.K. Gujral and P.V. Narasimha Rao, former prime minister Haradanahalli Doddegowda Deve Gowda, 75, is penning a four-volume autobiography about his five-decade political career. The JD(s) supremo recently handed over the leadership mantle to his son H.D. Kumaraswamy, who followed his father as a chief minister of Karnataka. The book will throw light on his uneasy relationship with leaders and his bete noires like Ramakrishna Hegde, who died in 2004; how the Congress, the party that he began his political career at the age of 20, dethroned him as prime minister after eleven months in power in April 1997 and the leadership battle in his Vokkaliga community, the state's second-largest caste group. Not known to be an eloquent speaker, Gowda's book may turn out to be an interesting read. *by Stephen David*

**DEVE GOWDA  
WILL SPEND  
TIME WRITING  
A FOUR-  
VOLUME AUTO-  
BIOGRAPHY  
ABOUT HIS  
FIVE-DECADE  
POLITICAL  
CAREER.**



SIPRA DAS